



Atchafalaya State University president suspends all fraternities over widespread hazing allegations

By [Greg Winnipeg](#)

Oct. 13 — The president of Atchafalaya State University, Frederick Pierce, announced this morning that all Greek life organizations have been temporarily suspended, effective immediately. This suspension comes amid the re-emergence of hazing allegations connected to the death of 19-year-old James O'Connor in September of last year, an incident that made [national headlines](#).

O'Connor's drowned body was found on the banks of the Atchafalaya River nine days after the freshman from Hammond received a bid — the term used for an invitation to membership — from the Omega chapter of Gamma Kappa Epsilon. According to the police report, his arms were bound behind his back with duct tape.

While no members of the fraternity were formally charged, O'Connor's family filed a [lawsuit against Gamma Kappa Epsilon](#), the university and Omega chapter co-presidents, twin brothers Mason Morales and Dillon Morales, in July. This suit prompted the re-opening of ASU's investigation, which was previously closed last year after President Pierce, speaking on behalf of the campus safety department, asserted it was impossible to determine fault in the case.

The family's suit alleges that, as part of his initiation, O'Connor was intimidated into attempting to swim across the river while intoxicated and wearing the makeshift restraints. During this ritual, O'Connor struggled to remain afloat, and, rather than seek help, the suit claims his fraternity brothers fled the scene.

Members of Gamma Kappa Epsilon have denied any responsibility for O'Connor's death. In response to the O'Connors' suit, Daniella Morales, mother of the Morales brothers, [filed a countersuit for defamation](#) on her children's behalf.

In a statement to the press, Dillon Morales said, "Jim was our much-loved brother, but that night, he made a string of poor decisions that ended in tragedy. As president, I have made it a priority to engage in open and frank conversations with my brothers about the dangers of binge drinking, and I will continue to do so."

In the aftermath of the tragedy last year, the Morales brothers voluntarily canceled their ASU matriculation.

Fraternity and sorority members are advised to wait patiently as the university determines the results of the investigation. President Pierce assured students and parents that there will be no tolerance for hazing and abuse on the Atchafalaya campus.

